Subject: Re: Request reviewer comments
Date: Thursday, November 20, 2025 at 1:27:11 PM Eastern Standard Time
From: Veer Shetty
To: David Smith

Hi Dr. Smith,

It is always disappointing to me, as the messenger, to deliver the rejections to some great proposals that may have been funded if we had a larger budget. The competition was indeed high this year with our lowest funding rate yet (10%).

Please see the list of winners and their projects here:
https://www.cuny.edu/research/research-development-programs/faculty-programs/internal-funding/interdisciplinary-research-grant-program/irg-grant-winners/

Some IRG Metadata here:

- $345,000 total awarded to 6 projects (14 faculty)
- 60 applications received and reviewed
- Fourteen (14) faculty representing nine (9) colleges/schools (Lehman, Queens, Hunter, CSI, Medgar, Brooklyn, CCNY, York, SPH)
- Four of the six projects led by junior faculty/assistant professors

Please see your reviewer comments below:

- This is a highly original and ambitious proposal that redefines the boundary between tradition and technology. It offers a well-conceived model of how cultural heritage can inform, and not merely adapt to, emerging technological systems. The integration of gamelan, wayang kulit, and AI performance through CHI's holistic framework demonstrates both academic depth and public value. The main area for improvement lies in expanding methodological specificity—particularly how human–machine interaction will be analyzed and assessed. Overall, this is a compelling and forward-thinking project that positions CUNY as a leader in culturally informed technological research.
- The proposal was interesting from an arts perspective but didn't seem like it had any solid technical grounding. The proposal mentions AI and other technologies many times but never actually describes how they will be used in the research.
- This proposal stands out for its creativity and bold interdisciplinarity, merging traditional cultural practices like gamelan and shadow puppetry with emerging technologies and AI collaboration. Its strength lies in its innovative fusion of art, heritage, and technology, which could inspire meaningful dialogue on human–machine coexistence. However, its outcomes—centered on creativity, collaboration, and cultural interpretation—are highly subjective and difficult to measure or generalize, which may limit the project's evaluative rigor and broader research impact despite its strong artistic and conceptual vision.

Best,

Veer

From: David Smith <DSMITH@CityTech.Cuny.Edu>
Date: Wednesday, November 19, 2025 at 4:37 PM
To: Veer Shetty <veer.shetty@cuny.edu>
Subject: Request reviewer comments

Good afternoon.

I was saddened to see that our team (*Holistic Integration as Convergent Innovation: Blended Shadow Puppetry, Gamelan, and Collaborative AI*) was not awarded the CUNY IRG grant, but I completely understand that the competition was fiercer than in the past, and I am sure there were many worthy initiatives that you were unable to fund.

It would be of great use to receive the reader's comments so that we could better understand the scope and requirements and how we may improve our submission in future applications.

Thank you in advance for sharing any insights in this regard.

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